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THREATS AND TREATS, INDIAN AND HOMEGROWN

1999. A military coup was about to hit Pakistan. Before that, the Kargil conflict would erupt between India and Pakistan. The stakes for peace were higher, we all knew. Both countries had conducted nuclear tests in 1998. I remember kids wearing 'Nuclear Powered Pakistani' T-shirts in Karachi. Nationalism was soaring in the subcontinent.

Still, when it started, 1999 bode well. Pakistan visited India for its first Test tour after thirteen years. That was most of my life, at that point. The gallant Wasim Akram, who would break Imran Khan's record of 362 Test wickets in the series, was captain of the side. Shehryar Khan, a gentleman-diplomat, was team manager. He would eventually become chairman of the Pakistan Cricket Board (PCB).

This was no ordinary tour – we all knew it. It didn't matter who would win. The 1999 tour was about history – the one that had been written and the one we were about to rewrite. A lot more than Test records were at stake. Unfortunately, prior to the tour, Indian nationalism turned into hyper nationalism. The right-wing Hindu supremacist group, the Shiv Sena, dug up the Delhi pitch at the Feroz Shah Kotla Stadium and damaged it badly. They attacked the offices of the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) in Mumbai. They even threatened to attack the Pakistan players. In short, they did all they could to disallow the series even before we set foot in India. (Apparently, the BCCI had to hire snake charmers to stay in the stands because the Shiv Sena had threatened to let loose cobras at the grounds.) There were protests in several cities – both for and against the series. This wasn't just any other tour – after all, Indian special forces commandos were to escort us everywhere in the country.

Sadly, the batting on that tour was below average. Just two players, India's Sadagoppan Ramesh and I, crossed the 200-run mark. The Delhi Test had to be moved to Chennai. We all came back to a terrible wicket in Delhi, though, and let 'Jumbo', Anil Kumble's new avatar, run